Singing Me Softly...

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Abstract

This short paper will consider the Oracular powers of Sound in the prediction and construction of imaginative Utopic (and Dystopic) futures - in effect a pre-technological form of Virtual Reality. I will discuss the traditional fusion of site, sculpture, speech and belief systems, which characterise Oracles and then focus upon the relationship of Sound to Political power and territorial conflict. The final section of the paper will examine the re-emergence of Sound as a spatialising metaphor and agent in Cinema and in immersive Virtual Reality systems.

Dr. Nigel Helyer is an Australian Sculptor and Sound-Artist with an International reputation for his architectural scale sound installations, public art projects and experimental radio broadcasts.

His initial formation as a sculptor has provided him with an orientation insistent upon an experiential, rather than a representational means of expression - one in which the body, its sensorium and its memory, is invoked as the primary location of meaning. This has drawn him toward an area of research and practice which seeks to critique and develop a nexus of relationships between the body, sound and public space.

He is currently the Artist in Residence at Lake Technology (Sydney) where he is undertaking Research and Development of the virtual audio reality project “Sonic Landscapes”. He is an International commissioner for the “SoundCulture” organisation, a consultant to the “ReSonance” sound-art festival (Seoul 2001) and a member of the New Media Board of the Australia Council.

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